CHAPTER 9

# HEROES

*6 July 1986*

I am four years old. He's been on the television all summer. There's something about the way he plays the game, something that he is articulating to me through the television, that has left a thunderbolt of an impression on me. When he serves, he throws the ball into the sky, and for a second, it is as if time suspends. He is poised and coiled, left arm reaching towards the sky, the ball still connected to his palm by some invisible force, both knees bent, before he rotates through the ball and his racquet unleashes as if all the time before it has been held and then released, spinning to catch up with itself. He seems slightly sheepish, self-effacing even, but when the ball is in motion and as soon as play is active, there is a calm. When the absolute centre of attention, it's like he is suddenly in total control, his every move so graceful and athletic. He is also throwing himself on the floor often, and people are applauding him for it. It's quite appealing. By the time he reaches the final of Wimbledon, I want nothing else than to be Boris Becker.

Becker plays Ivan Lendl at the centre of the global tennis calendar year, all eyes on him. There are no phones, no distractions. On days like this, it feels as if not only the whole of Burnley has quietened, everyone watching it, but the world outside too. Despite this pressure, he appears that day on television with an effortlessness that suggests it's just play to him, something that comes innately. By the end of his straight sets win, I have reorganised the living room as a vision of Centre Court. The settee is the net and after I watch every point, I recreate it exactly with the plastic racquet and soft balls I've been given by my parents – they do less damage and